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Cedar Rapids police expanding use of Automated License Plate Readers

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CEDAR RAPIDS, Iowa (KCRG) - The Cedar Rapids Police Department is in the processes of installing 75 new Automated License Plate Readers across the city.



The cameras read license plates of cars as they pass by, alerting police if someone they are looking for drives by. For around 10 years, the department had two of these cameras attached to patrol cars.

The i9 Investigative team learned that the city of Cedar Rapids [signed a two-year contract this summer with Flock Group for nearly half a million dollars to add 75 cameras](#). 61 are already up in a fixed location across the city. “We have another nine that have yet to be put up,” says Cedar Rapids Police Chief David Dostal. “And then the other five are going to be pan, tilt, zoom, cameras that are going to be deployed in the downtown area to assist with any issues we have downtown.”

Chief Dostal says the cameras help officers arrest people with outstanding warrants, find stolen cars, and locate missing people. He says the new cameras have played a part in more than 30 arrests since going up in October.

“There was a domestic violence abuse incident where the use of Flock cameras along with the traffic cameras were, directed officers...we located the vehicle that ended up in a domestic abuse arrest in which a 15-month old was in the car and the 15 month old was returned to safety,” says Dostal.

Chief Dostal says the cameras are a tremendous help for officers, but organizations like the [ACLU of Iowa have raised concerns](#) that these cameras could be an invasion of privacy.

Dostal says the cameras are objective, and points out that the data is automatically deleted after 30 days. “This is just one more tool that we can use, again officers can’t be every place at every time,” says Dostal. “It does give a safe environment to to live, to work and to visit.”

The contract also provides police with a live view. There is one thing the cameras can’t do—enforce traffic laws like speeding or running red lights.

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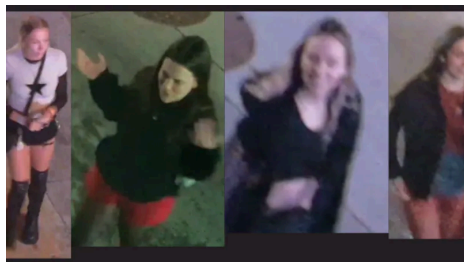
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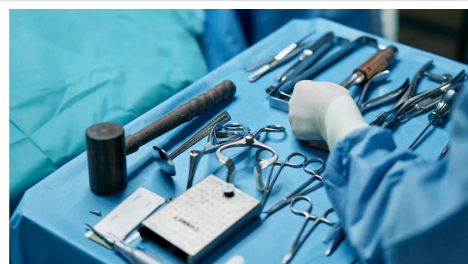
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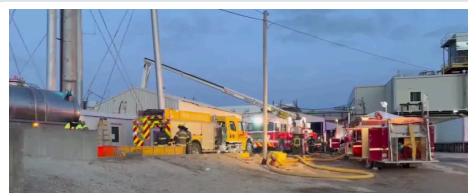
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